

CONVERSATIONS AT CORNAFULLA

Cornafulla Micro Reserve

Thursday 30 July 2026

Bog Bothy, Cornafulla Bog

4.30pm – Law and Environment

Chaired by **Ella McSweeney**, journalist, broadcaster and presenter, with **Thomas Ball**, Nature, Biodiversity and Land Use Lead at KPMG Ireland; **Dr Alison Hardiman**, barrister and consultant in climate and environmental law; and **Fred Logue**, environmental and planning lawyer.

5.45pm – Nature and Education

With **Patrick Kirwan**, science teacher and Director of the Irish Schools Sustainability Network, and **Dr Jessica Foley**, lecturer, poet and researcher

4.30pm – Law and Environment

When policy does not decide, what decides the future of a bog? Law, land use and ecological recovery at Cornafulla

Cornafulla exposes a structural question in Irish land use. A bog may be treated at once as public land, restoration candidate, hydrological system, carbon store, habitat and development target, while also sitting within the context of protected sites. Irish bogs are internationally significant landscapes, yet some bogs with clear ecological and restoration significance remain outside direct legal protection, even where their hydrology and habitat function support protected sites nearby.

Once those functions come into conflict, the State has not clearly stated by what legal logic one public objective may override another. Yet the matter does not remain still. Pumping, infrastructure preparation, future applications and other incremental administrative acts can begin to decide the outcome before the higher conflict has ever been squarely resolved.

This raises some linked questions. Can law treat a bog as divisible and still claim to be protecting the thing itself? What happens when the State pursues green energy without first resolving how ecologically sensitive land is to be valued and governed? And what legal

logic decides when climate action, biodiversity protection, water regulation and public-land management are weighed against one another, and on what kind of land?

The discussion asks whether bogs have become a clear test of legal coherence in Irish land use: a place where climate ambition, biodiversity law, water protection, public-land governance and infrastructure policy collide, while the underlying hierarchy of decision-making remains unsettled.

Thomas Ball – Nature, Biodiversity and Land Use Lead at KPMG Ireland

A scientist by training, Thomas has more than 20 years' experience in sustainability strategy, policy, advocacy and communications. Before joining KPMG, he was Head of Business Advocacy at WWF, working with financial institutions and businesses on the transition to a net-zero and nature-positive economy. He was a technical member of the UK Government's Transition Plan Taskforce and lead author of *The Nature of Finance*, a study of nature-related risks, impacts and dependencies in the Irish financial sector.

Dr Alison Hardiman – Barrister and Consultant in Climate and Environmental Law

Alison is a consultant in the Climate and Environment practice at Philip Lee. She specialises in planning and environmental law, with particular expertise in strategic infrastructure and renewable energy within Irish and European legal frameworks. She previously served as lead in-house planning lawyer for Transport Infrastructure Ireland. Her 2024 PhD examined how environmental protection and climate mitigation can be reconciled in EU law, with particular reference to renewable-energy project authorisation. She has served on the Government's Major Projects Advisory Group since 2022.

Fred Logue – Environmental and Planning Lawyer

Fred is managing partner of FP Logue LLP and specialises in planning, environmental and information law. With a background in science and engineering, he has extensive experience in environmental and planning litigation, acting primarily for members of the public, community associations and environmental organisations. His firm's work has included major Irish and European cases, including the successful challenge to the Government's national climate plan. He also advises on freedom of information and access to environmental information.

Ella McSweeney – Journalist, Broadcaster and Presenter

Ella is a journalist, broadcaster and presenter specialising in food, farming, science and the environment. A zoology graduate of Trinity College Dublin, she also holds a master's degree in Food Policy. She has more than 25 years' experience across RTÉ, the BBC, The Guardian and The Irish Times. Her work includes *Ear to the Ground*, *CountryWide* and radio and television documentaries on agriculture, wildlife, science and rural life, alongside investigative reporting on farming, environmental policy, land use and ecological change.

5.45pm – Nature and Education

Nature at the Centre – Changing education for biodiversity, climate and the future children are inheriting

This discussion asks what it would take to make nature central to education, rather than treating it as optional enrichment, a once-off outdoor activity, or something that depends on a few exceptional teachers, schools or local projects.

The climate and biodiversity crises are not only scientific or policy problems. They are also educational problems. Young people are inheriting a changing world, but many still pass through education with limited direct knowledge of the living systems that support health, food, water, climate resilience, community and economy. Guidelines and good intentions do not automatically become classroom practice. Teachers and schools need training, time, resources, confidence, outdoor learning spaces and local partners if nature is to become part of the core work of education.

Cornafulla Bog offers a direct way into this question. A bog is not empty ground. It is a living system of water, carbon, species, memory, local knowledge and restoration potential. As part of the Bog Bothy programme, this discussion asks how places like Cornafulla can help children, schools, colleges and communities understand nature as essential knowledge, rather than as something separate from everyday life.

The panel brings together national work on nature and climate education, practical experience in schools, perspectives from higher education and research, and the long-term influence of growing up with access to a school-linked bog reserve.

Together, these perspectives ask how nature education can move from individual enthusiasm to a shared culture of learning. The wider question is simple but urgent: how do we educate for the future children are actually inheriting?

Patrick Kirwan – Science Teacher and Director of the Irish Schools Sustainability Network

Patrick is a science and biology teacher at Ardscoil na Mara in Tramore and founding director of the Irish Schools Sustainability Network. The network supports schools across Ireland in embedding climate, biodiversity and sustainability in teaching and everyday school life. His work combines national advocacy, teacher support and student participation through initiatives including the Climate and Nature Summit, the Student Ambassador Programme, 5 Minutes of Sustainability and Bitesize Biodiversity. At Ardscoil na Mara, he has worked with students to create outdoor classrooms, a greenhouse and wildlife areas, helping young people respond to climate anxiety through knowledge, participation and meaningful action.

Dr Jessica Foley – Lecturer, Poet and Researcher

Jessica is a Lecturer in Critical and Contextual Studies at the Institute of Art, Design and Technology, Dún Laoghaire. Her work brings together writing, education, communication

and collaborative forms of enquiry. She completed a doctorate at Trinity College Dublin and later held an Irish Research Council postdoctoral fellowship at Maynooth University. Her research and creative practice explore how reading, writing and conversation can bring people together around shared questions. She also has a personal connection to Killaun Bogland Reserve through her father, Tom Foley, founder of the reserve. This informs the perspective she brings to the long-term educational value of access to a bog through school, family and community.

Train pickup: Athlone station, 3.00pm. Return at 7.30pm for evening Galway and Dublin trains. **Advance booking essential:** cornafullamicroreserve@proton.me

Directions from Athlone: Take the old Ballinasloe Road/Galway Road to Michael Kenny Car Sales (N37 X9A2). Turn onto the L2036 towards Creggan and continue for 6 minutes. At the T-junction, keep right and remain on the L2036.

Nearest Eircode: N37 FF10

Full programme at <https://www.cornafullamicroreserve.com/schedule.html>
Events include outdoor activities, so please wear suitable clothing and sturdy footwear.

The programme coincides with Amanda Ralph's solo exhibition, [FIELD STATION: CORNAFULLA](#), at Luan Gallery, Athlone, until 30 August 2026.

Bog Bothy is a partnership project between the Irish Architecture Foundation and 12th Field, co-created with local communities.

The Bog Bothy 2026 tour is funded by Tóchar. Managed by the National Parks and Wildlife Service, Tóchar is a three-year wetlands restoration project co-funded by the Government of Ireland and the European Union through the EU Just Transition Fund.



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